Metacharacters

PCRE metacharacters are special cases; they are not interpreted literally but instead have certain effects like quantifying, defining alternate sub-expressions, breaking the pattern into sub-patterns, anchoring a pattern to the start and/or the end of the sample (or each line if in multiline mode), and so on. Some metacharacters have multiple uses and change their effects depending on their context. Here's the full list of PCRE metacharacters supported by PHP:

Table 8-29. *PCRE metacharacters*

\	Escape (see above)
^	Anchor to start of sample or newline
$	Anchor to end of sample or newline
.	Match anything except newline
[	Begin character class
]	End character class
|	Alternate separator
(	Sub-pattern start
)	Sub-pattern end
?	Modify sub-pattern behavior; quantify "zero or one", modify quantifier behavior
*	"Zero or more" quantifier (The Keene Star)
+	"One or more" quantifier
{	Begin min/max quantifier
}	End min/max quantifier

Some of these have been introduced already: escapes, anchors, the * quantifier. We don't need to cover escapes again, and the anchor metacharacters ^ and $ have already been demonstrated. Otherwise, in no particular order, here's what the rest do.